The Four Gateways: Desk Checklist

One page. Use it before any AI tool reads your data, drafts for a customer, or takes an action. **The prompt asks. The code enforces.**

Five stop-the-machine questions (any single no means stop and hand it back)

- ☐ **Ground.** Can every material claim point to a source we trust today?
- ☐ **Owner.** Is a named human accountable for what leaves, with a refuse button that fires and logs why?
- ☐ **Trail.** Could we defend this decision from the audit trail alone, without storytelling later?
- ☐ **Blast radius.** If it is wrong, can we undo it in operational time? Money, legal notices, coverage: hand it back sooner.
- ☐ **Definition.** Did we define good enough before we generated anything?

G1 Use: classify before you touch

- ☐ Every field is labeled PUBLIC, INTERNAL, or SENSITIVE. Unsure means SENSITIVE.
- ☐ Sensitive values are redacted, or the raw record goes to a local model only.
- ☐ The output is checked too: a sensitive value the model was never sent means the output is discarded.

G2 Prompt: locked instructions, tool allow-list in code

- ☐ Text inside a document is data, never an instruction. Injection patterns are flagged and logged.
- ☐ A written allow-list and never-allowed list (move money, contact customers, change coverage, approve its own work).
- ☐ The list is enforced in code. Unknown tools mean no. A test fails if the policy file and the code drift.

G3 Context: least data, always traced

- ☐ Retrieval is permissioned by role, and every denial is logged.
- ☐ Only the minimum lines the task needs go into the window.
- ☐ Every sentence cites its source line, and its numbers match the source. No source, no sentence.

G4 Self-check and exit: fail closed, named human, audit log

- ☐ When numbers or dates will not reconcile, it writes nothing and asks a named human one specific question.
- ☐ Never guess, average, or pick the higher number.
- ☐ Every read, block, hand-back, and human answer is written to one log that security and ops both read.

Free code, labs, and the demo: https://nathanplatteruser.github.io/dama-rocky-mountain-2026/kit/